Preface to DMC Course

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1. Genesis of the Course: Getting Perspective on Mind Control

I do not think I am going out on a limb in assuming that everyone taking this course has been observing the American and world political scene for decades. A line that comes to mind is, "When I think of the road we're traveling on, I wonder what's gone wrong. I can't help it. I wonder what's gone wrong."[1] Granted, not all of you will be obsessed with the dark side. Some know that focusing on the positive is a better way of making a hopeful prophecy self-fulfilling. Think, for example, of the line "The arc of the moral universe is long, but it bends toward justice.[2]"

Whether we dwell on what has gone wrong or place our faith in progress, both perspectives reflect the power of ideas to shape how we see the world. For my purposes in trying to control you to be receptive to what I have to say, let us agree that not only does every political act involve an element of mind control, but so does every act of communication — including thought, which is an act of communication with ourselves.

Aspects of Mind Control

We all have a collection of perhaps contradictory senses of what mind control means. For the purposes of this course, I am interested less in a single universal definition of mind control than in sorting through different aspects of mind control. To this end, let me start by distinguishing between constructive and destructive mind control, between individual and systemic mind control, and between threatening and enticing mind control.

Constructive vs. Destructive Mind Control Constructive mind control offers options to improve how we think and feel. Think of an inspiring teacher whose goal is not to dazzle students, but to get them to think for themselves.

Destructive mind control, on the other hand, manipulates people into thinking within a rigid framework that harms its recipients in the long run. Think about cults[3], brainwashing prisoners of war[4], or dictators who rule by fear or spin[5]. Or think about people who crowd out all reason by mindlessly repeating clichés and slogans, filling our minds and media with bullshit[6]. Speaking of media, the proliferation of media

[1] Quoted lyric from "American Tune" by Paul Simon.
[2] MLK said this in his "How Long, Not Long" speech. The line has evolved from sermons of Theodore Parker since before the American Civil War.
[3] See Steven Hassan's books on cults.
[4] See *The Instability of Truth* by Rebecca Lemov.
[5] See *Spin Dictators* by Sergei Guriev & Daniel Treisman.
[6] See *Stupid Idiots* by Lars Svendsen and *On Bullshit* by Harry G. Frankfurt.

today (social media, blogs, podcasts, and now AI) exerts tremendous control on the kind of messages we communicate[7].

Individual vs. Systemic Mind Control Systemic, or system-wide, mind control is what is imposed upon us—either for good or bad—by society. It is structural. It is the water we swim in that we cannot always even see. Think, for example, of the phrase "under God being inserted into the Pledge of Allegiance in 1954 as part of the Cold War against "atheist communists."

Individual mind control is what friends, family, acquaintances, our bosses, our religious leaders, our therapists, or our teachers do to try to influence us. At the most personal level, it is what we ourselves do to try to control our own minds. This ranges from impulsively eating chocolate to perk ourselves up, to hours of silent meditation to calm the demons within. In modern parlance, it is the "executive function" decision not to be overwhelmed by anxiety caused by that bad math teacher[8] and instead to spend a fixed amount of time each day doing our best to learn before taking a break for a healthy diversion[9].

I am all too often a glass-half-empty kind of guy. Plus, I have a mathematician's obsession with looking for patterns, and have a penchant for theories of everything. So, the kind of mind control I have worried about for a long time is destructive and systemic. For the purposes of our course, this is the form of mind control on which we will focus most.

In real life, the dichotomies above may be useful but can also be quite fuzzy. I hope you will help me break out of my own controlled brain and explore these distinctions rather than use them rigidly.

Threatening vs. Enticing Mind Control Threatening mind control relies on provoking negative emotions. A systemic and destructive form of this is a dictatorship that keeps power through actual or implied punishment.

Enticing mind control - mind control with a carrot - uses the allure of comfort or riches. A systemic and destructive version of this may take the form of lulling people into complacency by not only providing for their needs, but by creating a dependency on "false needs".

More Features of Mind Control Instances There are many other features of mind control.

For example, the **conceptual vs affective** feature measures whether control is acting more directly on reasoning or on emotion. Sometimes we can be tricked into thinking we are being reasonable, when actually an emotional pull or push is acting on us.

The **extremist vs balanced** feature gauges whether the controller is always pushing a swinging pendulum toward one extreme versus nudging toward equilibrium.

Another feature measures whether a mind control instance is intended to make people **stop thinking** or if it is meant to **encourage thought**. Stopping thought is likely to be destructive. That is not to say that all forms of encouraging thought are constructive. For example, encouraging harmful thinking, encouraging people to stew in their own thoughts, and encouraging violent dissent can all be destructive.

The **simplicity vs complexity** feature gauges whether an instance of mind control pushes people toward black-and-white simplicity or encourages people to engage with complexity. Individuals vary in their susceptibility to pressure to think one way or another. Simplicity can be useful for cutting through noise, but oversimplification can lead people to jump quickly to wrong conclusions[10]. The tendency to stop thinking is probably highly correlated with the tendency to oversimplify.

[7] See *The Medium is the Message* by Marshall McLuhan. Think about how media and culture have co-evolved to saturate us with infotainment, which trains us to need to be entertained when learning. Participants may well wonder: How much is this course affected by that?

[8] Apologies to my former students if I have afflicted you this way.

[9] Apologies to myself for the times I have obsessively not followed this strategy.

[10] One of my favorite quotes is by Oliver Wendell Holmes, Senior, the father of the supreme court justice: "For the simplicity on this side of complexity, I wouldn't give you a fig. But for the simplicity on the other side of complexity, for that I would give you anything I have."

Real-life examples of mind control don't always fit neatly into the simplified binary choices above. Often, they have some combination of the different possibilities. For example, a spin dictator[11] may rely on partial truths to encourage only limited thinking, so that people can't properly assess who is offering carrots and who is offering sticks.

There are many other features that can be used to characterize the nature of instances of mind control. The features are correlated; that is, having one value of a particular feature says something about the likelihood of another feature's value. For example, if a particular case of mind control works by threat, it is more likely to be destructive as well.

2. Shaping the Container

I have spent a long, lonely time[12] striving to understand magic formulas to overcome systemic destructive mind control and "get back to the garden."[13] As you can see from the kind of data analysis approach of the previous section, I am backing down from trying to find solutions to simply trying to find relevant questions to ask[14].

To encourage the study group to question my biases, I will now admit something. My thinking about mind control has been affected by intense interactions I have had with individuals, and by the particular slice of media I consume. This experience leads me to focus on particular notions about mind control and to worry about how other people's minds are being over-controlled by certain myths.

A course—not this course—that I have fantasized about putting together would be a kind of philosophical list of do's and don'ts for a mature thinker thinking about politics, religion, science, and life, with examples chosen and motivated by my personal experience.

When I started to think of putting together a real course—this course for BOLLI—I realized I needed to get out of my own personal information bubble in order to gain a broader perspective and avoid having the course degenerate into narrow commentary on current politics and personal grievances.

I think abstract themes are only useful if tested against evidence. Unfortunately, a consequence of the polarization our society is currently experiencing is that we cannot even agree on what facts are important, or even what facts are true. So, I decided to step back—or you could call it a retreat—to the world of fiction, where at least we all have equal access to the core facts: those presented in the story being focused on.

To make the course more accessible as a sort of introductory sampler, we will focus on three films and a short story. The heart of this course will be class discussion based on the sequence of stories we will all be reading or watching, discussion questions about the stories, and short quotes from the stories so that we are starting from the same place.

For each story, I will suggest a tool or "lens" we can use to look at the story. These lenses are just suggestions to foster thinking and discussion; they are not meant to be a barrier of abstractions. The primary goal will be to encounter the stories in their own terms. A consistent discussion point about all the stories:

- *How is the story relevant to the issues today, and to each of us on a personal level?*

3. What We Will Be Exploring

I call the four stories we will consider, taken together, *an* arc of dystopian stories. Each story represents a kind of dystopia in which systemic forces are used to destructively control the minds of people in society.

[11] See *Spin Dictators* by Sergei Guriev & Daniel Treisman.

[12] "It's been a long time, been a long lonely, lonely, lonely time," is a line in "Rock and Roll (How the West Was Won)" by Led Zeppelin.

[13] "We are stardust, we are golden, and we've got to get ourselves back to the garden," is a line in "Woodstock by Joni Mitchell.

[14] It is sometimes said that the hallmark of a great physicist is the ability to home in on the relevant features (or variables) of a problem. In some sense, physicists face an easier task than what people studying human behavior face, because the results of experiments in physics are fairly repeatable, and often only a small number of variables are necessary to capture the essence of what is going on.

The protagonists in these stories represent hero figures struggling to see the light. The stories tell **tales of** attempted **defiance**.

The stories are dystopian in that each involves a kind of destructive mind control pervasively imposed by the world in which the protagonist lives. I will sometimes refer to the protagonists as "heroes", in the sense that most readers will be rooting for them in their attempts to resist mind control, not in the sense of foreshadowing that they will succeed.

The kind of **mind control** the hero is struggling against progresses from story to story, with an evolving, increasingly sophisticated mix of threat and enticement techniques, which are enabled by increasingly powerful, techniques available to the state (or corporations or machines). The techniques of control are cumulative. Just because a new technique evolves, doesn't mean the old ones disappear. In fact, we are struggling today with the techniques in all of the stories in the arc we will consider.

I italicized the first word of "*an* arc of dystopian stories" to make clear that these stories are simply the ones I have selected to demonstrate how the mind control techniques evolve. Sadly, there are many other prophetic choices we could pick. My hope is not that you will think of this arc as some sort of canon, but as an example of how you might get perspective by putting together an arc of stories that speak to you from literature, or your personal life.

As the techniques of dystopian mind control evolve, the tools we use to look at them co-evolve. You could think of them as "*an* arc of lenses", giving a sample of evolving ways to look at stories.

Below, I introduce each of the four stories we will look at. As I describe the stories, I will also introduce some lenses we will use to consider them, and questions that arise from those lenses. I will state the questions in this preface in a generic manner, which can be applied to any of the stories. When we cover individual stories, we will adapt the questions to the specific circumstances of the story. The fifth and last class will be devoted to overviewing what we have gotten from the arc as a whole.

4. An Arc of Stories and Lenses

Tale 1: *Notes from the Underground*

Lens: Human Outlier Analysis (Foucault – "Madness and Civilization")

Our first story, *Notes from the Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky, takes place at a time I am pegging as the start of the "modern age." The story was first published in Russian in 1864 and takes place in Petersburg around 1862-1864, as the American Civil War is raging and as people in Russia are losing faith in traditional institutions, particularly Tsarist government, and are struggling with whether and how to absorb the lessons of the Western Enlightenment.

The unnamed protagonist of the story, often referred to as Dostoevsky's Underground Man, is in many ways an antihero. He defies rationalism and scientism and their concomitant notions of what is considered sane and acceptable. Many of us today might see the Underground Man as crazy in his verbose rambling and perverse actions. He may seem preposterous and confused, but do we lose something important if he is ostracized as a mental defective?

If we try to understand the Underground Man, perhaps we can better understand our fellow citizens today who seem to want to roll back to a time before Enlightenment values. Perhaps we can learn to recognize that they have important insights, even as we may view them as crazy.

One tool we will introduce could be called human outlier analysis[15].

[15] On human outlier analysis, see:

- *Madness and Civilization* by Michel Foucault, 1961.

  This posits that a phenomenon of the Age of Reason is the attempt to eliminate the irrational from philosophical discourse. Institutions (such as hospitals and prisons) were developed to outcast radical thinkers as mad or criminal.

We will ask questions about the Underground Man that could well be asked of ourselves and those around us:

- *How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which they live, and how are they trying to influence that society?*
- *Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?*
- *Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?*
- *What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?*

Tale 2: *1984*

Lenses: The Police State (Foucault – Panopticon), Narrative Analysis (Bruner)

Our next story is *1984* by George Orwell, published in 1949, as society was struggling after WWII with how to face weapons of mass destruction: physical nuclear weapons, global technological warfare, and propaganda used for totalitarian control of minds.

We are all familiar with many references to how aspects of our current society are "Orwellian," with its police state[16] used to control outliers to the norms of society.

Many of us feel the constant stress of narratives[17] being imposed upon us, often without our conscious knowledge. Like the fish who does not have a concept for water, we may be unaware of how our thoughts are constrained by the hiding of evidence, which is made concrete in *1984* as the "memory hole". Or we may not notice how language can place limitations on our ability to think, as the language Newspeak is meant to do. Orwell's tale is so powerful because he has constructed a narrative, brilliantly written to focus on possibilities he sees with prophetic vision.

We will ask questions such as:

- *Mental control often attempts to flatten a person's inner life. How does the narrative use the "intentional states" (private thoughts) of the characters to defy the external world?*
- *In a "mentally controlled world," the system provides the "canonical script" (how one should think and act). How does the protagonist of our story create a "breach" in that script?*
- *In propaganda-heavy worlds, "truth" is whatever the state says. How does a "tale of defiance" use "narrative truth" to expose the lies of "systemic truth"?*
- *Why do we often use the "Dystopian" genre to talk about mental control? How does the genre itself help us understand what "defiance" looks like?*
- *What helps or hurts the ability of individual acts of defiance "accrue" into a movement?*

Tale 3: *The Matrix*

Lens: Analysis of Societal Control (Deleuze - Societies of Control)

[16] On the police state, see:

- Discipline & Punish (1975), Panopticism by Michel Foucault, Vintage Books, 1995, pp. 195-228 translated from the French by Alan Sheridan, 1977.

  > Bentham's Panopticon, designed in the late eighteenth century, was a prison model in which inmates could be watched without knowing when they were under observation, encouraging them to internalize discipline. In Discipline and Punish, Foucault develops this model into a metaphor for modern power: surveillance across schools, factories, hospitals, prisons, and society as a whole leads people to regulate themselves.

[17] On narrative analysis, see

- "The Narrative Construction of Reality", Jerome Bruner, Critical Inquiry, Vol. 18, No. 1, Autumn 1991.
- "Bruner's Narrative Theory for DMC Course".

In class three, we will focus on the 1999 movie *The Matrix*. The mind control here is total control of reality itself. Our hero, Neo, chooses to swallow the "red pill," which lets him see that the entire world he has been living in is an elaborate computer simulation.

The previous dystopian elements of controlling outliers via a kind of police state, and controlling the narrative through controlling language are relevant to this story. In addition, the movie is prophetic of the encroachment of virtual reality on our present-day world.

A tool here is to examine how society is being controlled[18].

We will ask questions such as:

- *Who or what is controlling society?*
- *How is it being controlled?*

Tale 4: *The Perfect Match*

Lenses: False Needs (Marcuse), Surveillance Capitalism (Zuboff)

In the short story "The Perfect Match," the protagonist, Sai, confronts the fact that his desires and preferences are not his own, but being fed to him through chatbots. This presents a modern look at the disappearing line between free will and the "suggestions" of corporate-controlled AI.

One issue this story raises is that of "false needs"[19], that is desires created by capitalist consumer society – such as the urge to buy certain products or have certain relationships – that seem personal but actually keep people dependent, distracted, and less free.

Also relevant is "surveillance capitalism"[20], which is the idea that companies profit by collecting, analyzing, predicting, and influencing people's behavior, turning personal data into a tool for influence and commercial gain.

- *Can you relate to how the protagonist is controlled through false needs?*
- *Can you relate to how our independence is limited because corporations are always observing us and trying to influence us?*

[18] On societies of control, see

- Postscript on the Societies of Control, Gilles Deleuze, L'Autre journal, no. 1, May 1990.
- Disciplinary societies and Societies of control, CourseCompendium.

> "The disciplinary societies, as defined by Foucault, are in the process of becoming societies of control, as defined by Deleuze, Chantal Mouffe (2012: 23) contends. This transition, which does not necessarily imply a complete replacement or displacement, is marked by the emergence of a new paradigm of power. In the disciplinary societies, command is exercised through the articulation of a network of apparatuses (dispositifs) that produce, and regulate customs, habits and practices of production, the major disciplinary institutions being the family, school, factories, asylums and hospitals. In societies of control, however, command is immanent to the social field, distributed to the minds and bodies of the citizens."

[19] On false needs, see:

- *One-Dimensional Man: Studies in the Ideology of Advanced Industrial Society*, Herbert Marcuse, Beacon Press, 1964.
- Herbert Marcuse's False Needs Theory – YouTube.
- From 1984 to One-Dimensional Man: Critical Reflections on Orwell and Marcuse, Douglas Kellner.

[20] On surveillance capitalism, see:

- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*, Shoshana Zuboff, Profile Books, 2019.

> "The titanic power struggles of the twentieth century were between industrial capital and labor, but the twenty-first century finds surveillance capital pitted against the entirety of our societies in a bloodless battle for power and profit as violent as any the world has seen."

- The Age of Surveillance Capitalism – Wikipedia.
- Shoshana Zuboff's The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: A Guide to Fighting Back – YouTube.

- *How important is privacy to the main character, and to you?*